

The road to Audiophilia is littered with a countless number of esoteric terms. To be an insider in this exclusive club, often knowing the jargon is the only way to get access. Mids, highs, lows, flat response, reference gear – what do these mean? These terms are not as complicated or difficult to understand as you might think.

Read our guide to understanding audio terminology and pretty soon you'll be talking like this: "Those high-impedance beyerdynamic cans I tried recently were difficult to drive and necessitated an amp, but the sound signature was devoid of any colouration; neither bright nor warm, just neutral. The soundstaging was phenomenal too! And the entire frequency range was reproduced perfectly – from deep lows to extreme highs – the drivers were pristinely accurate".

Give it a go, at least you start sounding like an audiophile, if not actually being one!

Impedance:

"Impedance" is the resistance against electrical flow. In the world of audio gear too, it means the same thing. Measured in Ohms, it basically denotes how difficult it is to move the speaker's driver. By and large, high impedance systems require more power to drive them, hence requiring an amplifier to enhance the signal.

Sensitivity:

Another often seen term in the specifications of audio systems (speakers or headphones) is "sensitivity". Sensitivity is the sound pressure level measurement (loudness) taken at a distance of one meter by applying one watt of power. The sensitivity is measured in decibels (dB). Therefore, all other things being constant a high sensitivity audio system will require less power to sound as loud.

Frequency response:

The entire audio signal coming out of a speaker belongs to different frequencies of the audio spectrum. The audio range of speaker systems (and the human ear) lies in the range of 20 Hz to 20,000 Hz. The frequency response of a speaker system denotes the range of the frequencies that it can reproduce effectively.